

Session 19: The Things of First Importance

Key Takeaways

- Paul purposefully structures the letter of 1 Corinthians in a way that makes chapter 15 the pinnacle of his argument.
- Paul uses God/Christ language in 1 Corinthians, not Father/Son.
- Paul sums up a fundamental part of the Gospel in verses 3-4, "... that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures."

1 Corinthians 15

Chapter 15 marks a crescendo in Paul's thought and brings all the themes together.

"[This chapter] forms not only the close and crown of the whole epistle, but also provides the key to its meaning from which light is shed onto the whole, and it becomes intelligible ... as a unity."

Barth, Karl (1933). *The Resurrection of the Dead*. Hodder & Stoughton. Cited in Thiselton, Anthony (2013). [*The First Epistle to the Corinthians*](#). Eerdmans. 1169.

Many commentators note the rhetorical structure of 1 Corinthians 15.

- 1-11: The resurrection of Christ (Narratio)
- 12-19: The denial of the resurrection (First Refutatio)
- 20-28: The consequences of Christ's resurrection (First Confirmatio)
- 29-34: Arguments from Christian experience (First Confirmatio)
- 35-39: The resurrection body (Second Refutatio)
- 50-57: Victory over death (Second Confirmatio)
- 58: Conclusion for the Corinthians (Peroratio) (Malcolm, 2012)

In the rhetorical structure, Thiselton points out that the linchpin of the argument is verse 34: "Come back to your senses as you ought, and stop sinning; for there are some who are ignorant of God—I say this to your shame." They think they know God, but they have no knowledge of God (Thiselton, 2006).

God/Christ Language

Paul uses God/Christ language in 1 Corinthians and not Father/Son. He also emphasizes the all-encompassing nature of God. Why does he do this?

Thiselton cites James Moffatt on 1 Corinthians 15:28, who believed that Paul is attacking a "form of Christ-mysticism which loosened the nexus between God and Christ" (Moffatt, 1938).

“[Moffatt] explains the so-called subordinationism of the God-Christ relationship in this epistle in different terms. He proposes that, surrounded by cozy cult deities of the mystery cults and Graeco-Roman religion, the church at Corinth too readily appropriated a ‘Lord Jesus’ cult mind-set without sufficiently ‘serious reverence for a supreme deity over the universe,’ viewing ‘God’ as a shadowing figure in contrast to the passionate, intimate, devotion offered by others to Serapis or Asclepios or by Christians to Jesus as Lord.”

Moffatt, James (1938). [*First Epistle*](#). 250-51. Cited in Thiselton, Anthony (2013). [*The First Epistle to the Corinthians*](#). Eerdmans. 68.

Fee also refers to Moffatt as identifying a Greco-Roman tendency to gather around a heroic or divine figure without the inclusion of any serious reverence “for a supreme, central deity” (Fee, 1991).

Paul’s emphasis on “God” in this case would be specifically to correct this imbalance. Whether this was the case or not is not verifiable. However, the emphasis that Paul places on the supremacy of God and on the all-encompassing nature of God even in relation to Christ in this epistle is undeniable.

Thiselton notes in [1:2](#), at the very beginning, that τοῦ θεοῦ is possessive, serving Paul’s point that the church belongs solely to God, and therefore, not to any factions or domineering leaders. He writes, “[t]he church, Paul insists, belongs not to the wealthy, or to ‘patrons,’ or to some self-styled inner circle of ‘spiritual people who manifest gifts,’ but to God” (Thiselton, 2006).

Everything Comes Back to God

Paul says to them, “I make known now the gospel that I proclaimed to you, which you received and in which you stand, by which you are being saved, if you hold firmly to the word I preached to you. Otherwise, you have believed in vain” ([1 Cor. 15:1-2](#)).

They are standing in the Gospel and they are being saved, but there is a condition in there—to hold firmly to Paul’s word that he preached. If they don’t do this, then they have believed without a reason.

Thiselton prefers to translate εἰς ἄν (Greek: *eike*) as “incoherent” rather than “in vain” (2006). The point is that it is senseless belief if it is not belief in Paul’s Gospel that he preached.

And then Paul clarifies what he taught them and delivers to them the foremost or principal aspects of what he had received. The Gospel is handed on from one generation to another. He sums this up: “That Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures.”

Atonement Theology

This is the essence of the atonement and is a phrase that is taken up in the creeds in the 4th century C.E. as the central statement of our belief in relation to the atonement.

The writers of the New Testament and the creeds don’t give us one particular metaphor or model of the atonement as more important than the others. This is the most important principle—that Christ died for our sins. Second, that he was buried (i.e., that he fully died in his body). Third, that he was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures.

(This is seen to be a bit problematic because there is no explicit statement about Christ rising on the third day in the Hebrew Bible, so “on the third day according to the Scriptures” is quite difficult to pin down precisely. Scholars imagine that the Scriptures have a narrative of vindication or salvation on the third day and that this was what Paul was alluding to.)

Paul then cites some, not all, of the resurrection appearances: He appeared to Cephas (this is Paul’s name for Peter), then the twelve, the 500, James (not recorded as a resurrection appearance), then the apostles, and last of all as the miscarriage or abortion he appeared to me.

It’s strange that he doesn’t mention the women here. We don’t know why. Maybe he’s appealing to the men and so he cites the men?

He uses the term *ἐκτρώματι* (Greek: *ektromati*), which means abnormal birth or abortion. It could be that this is an insult that he’s using about himself, the least of the apostles, not fit to be an apostle, but then he turns this into a positive thing and a lesson about grace.

1 Corinthians 15:9-11 NIV

⁹ For I am the least of the apostles and do not even deserve to be called an apostle, because I persecuted the church of God. ¹⁰ But by the grace of God I am what I am, and his grace to me was not without effect. No, I worked harder than all of them—yet not I, but the grace of God that was with me. ¹¹ Whether, then, it is I or they, this is what we preach, and this is what you believed.

It also reinforces the idea that God brings abundant life and redemption out of what has come to nothing or died and sets him up for the next section.

Reflection Question

How does your understanding of the Gospel compare to what Paul writes about in this chapter?